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Th/r/ough/t/ Control: A Mediation on Metamorphosis

"Awareness is not a virtue in and of itself, not without a moral imperative."

—Imani Perry. *Breathe: A Letter to My Sons*.

"She knew nothing; no language, no history...she would not say of herself, I am this, I am that."

—Woolf, Virginia. *Mrs. Dalloway*.

"What I know and what I feel are two very different things."

—Gay, Roxane. *Hunger: A Memoir of (My) Body*.

Creases in clusters of clouds above me, pale white seeping in with the dusk summer sky. Loose strands of thin hair brush across my cheek, but I pay no attention. The clouds are far more fascinating. Here, it feels simple.

If I were to glance down, shatter the illusion of serenity, one more time, I would be ruined.

Above all, I know that my feelings would walk outside of my grasp, and I would not be able to catch up. Perhaps I could sit with what I know for a short while, but we are not close friends.

What is the cost of thought?

Know/Knew/Known = No New Known

I question my 'intelligence' quite often. I do not think I am 'intelligent.' There are others who have already thought my thoughts, no doubt. What good can my intuition make as just one person within the billions around me, billions before me, and billions after me? I remind myself of this often, even though it is entirely untruthful.

I have come to learn that my intuition is solely my own, a redundant observation and a quite delayed one at that. Understanding the needs of a sustainable life rooted in compassion and generosity at an early age placed me in this position—the people of hatred and spite that I have encountered have only pushed me further along. Many times, I have sat with my knees to my chest on the cold tiles of the bathroom floor, wandering lost in my mind on who to interrogate: my parents are not to blame, and while debates upon nature/nurture can continue cycling, I seek

no solace with their words; Mother Nature knows not of my worries, She simply fills the World with the green leaves and vibrant flowers and poisonous protectors; and I do not believe in God(s).

I like to pretend I do, sometimes, for the good of others. I'll whisper a prayer and "amen" when I see an ambulance fly past on the street; the passenger in the face of hardship, if not from their injury, then at least from the bill of that ride. I think it comes from my grandmother's Catholic faith, but I do not know how to make the cross with my hands, or what order the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit appear. I sit in silence, my hands on my lap, when she says grace before the meal she's cooked for me and my sister. I wonder if she is ever disappointed in me for never attending sermon. Or maybe my mother, who left the Catholic church to marry my father, a Lutheran. Maybe, she's upset that she knows I will never bring her great-grandchildren; maybe that grudge is burgeoned by my mother's indignation at my lifelong intent to escape woman-ness.

Am I to withstand and be misunderstood, or is it my own misunderstanding?

I like to imagine that I am not myself, just for a day. I'll act a little differently to see if anyone catches on. But I can never stray too far from my mind and flesh, no matter how hard I try. I think I know too much and too little about myself, about people, about life: it feels like it is my own secret deadweight.

That feeling only arises every once and a while, ever so often, when I lose sight of my self-critiquing fallacy, when I fail to see the minutes and seconds pass through my bodied growth. I seemingly feel and know the need to inscribe my waking hours: it is my welding of this double-edged sword to the page that provides both the paranoia and the reparative. *How?*

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I reckon that *dubito, ergo cogito, ergo sum*. I do not question my existence, nor do I carry suspicion for the existence of another. However, that existence feels like a singular grain of sand, and that aching question always plants itself deep within the crevices of my mind, whether deposited by my own thoughts or from others:

"Did I honestly think mine would be missed?" (p.73)

Sigrid Nunez vindicates this before me with her fictional novel, *The Friend*, and I want to weep. Is she asserting that her 'novel' —the auto-fictional mediation of her abstraction and grief of suicide in a decade-long friendship—therefore, her 'thoughts' are non-deserving of an audience, or are they simply non-acknowledged? What does Nunez feel, accosted by the surviving friend for placing her mind in fiction during times of dolefulness?

Will I be missed? What does it mean to be missed?

As someone who finds joy in genealogical research, I cannot help but perceive this problem as strangely unique: I do not forget the people I locate in my research. I am simply an aid to memory. My bookshelf beside my bed—tilting worryingly towards my headboard—is curated with second-hand novels, purposefully chosen to contain the prior owner's annotations in the margins. My closet, albeit the same color of clothing (curse tritanopia), is filled with fabrics from thrift stores and my grandfather's wardrobe. My (lack of) jewelry was selected carefully; I wear my grandmother's late best friend's gold-and-silver chain so I can bring both with me everywhere, since I always forget to fumble with the delicate clasp at night. Am I over-interpreting these performances of memory?

What if my only contribution to this Earth is mouth-gaping, trying to clear my mind underneath the clouds as my knowledge seeps beneath my feet?

It cannot be. I feel like it is not. I know it is not. Maybe.

Yet, I continue onwards. The only way I possess within both my mind and body: I must metamorphose this consolidated knowledge from the people I encounter. There is nothing new known, but this is no reason for paranoia.

Paranoia & Intimacy, or “Monstrous Vermin”

When I first read Eve Sedgwick's "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading, Or, You're So Paranoid You Probably Think This Essay is About You" in January of 2024, I was in a relationship with someone who had discovered the suicide of their parent two years prior. It was clear that the pains of parent-loss were still prevalent on the surface of their skin; our first conversation began because I questioned their absence from our shared course on Kurt Vonnegut, whom I called the 'Great Manipulator of Madness,'¹ which led to the disclosure of the aforesaid death.

I granted love. I could not fathom what it was like to feel and know that your parent is gone. But, due to my obsessive-compulsive disorder, I became paranoid about my partner following a similar path of intention as their parent: not only would the procurement of mortal threat linger, but I began to optimize my thoughts and time for an ameliorative existence, just not for me. I asked in the margins of "Paranoid Reading...", "is my belief of unattainability in

¹ This title was assigned in an essay I wrote in response to *Cat's Cradle*. In a following essay on *Slaughterhouse-Five*, I inquired: "to what extent does a novel delineate from its attempt to describe the subjective experience of Human amid chaos, and become an autobiographical rendition of the state of its author bounded by time and space?" (Oct/Nov 2023).

alignment with the 'paranoid' as determined through philological moral nihilism?" Was I simply a pawn of the graphic elements, the un/prejudicial part-object to the whole of unattainable human growth?

When my partner drew blood from me, I blamed it on their pain. I lay on the couch with my limbs frozen, as they fell asleep—hand on my bitten bicep—drowning from the copious amount of vodka in their mind.

When they sank to the floor of the dormitory bathroom, tears and thick slobbery streaming from eyes and nose and mouth, I blamed it on my pain. I lay on my bed with my limbs frozen, as they curled their arms into themselves atop my chest, weeping for clarity.

A stack of three sticky notes slapped on my 26 Jan 2024 journal entry:

"I did bad because my brain is a critic of my own life and I don't know how to turn it off."

The 30th of January, my 20th birthday:

"...[they] texted me within the last minute of my birthday, saying [they] hold nothing against me, and that [they're] 'willing' to let me heal."

The 22nd of February, continued to a second page:

"...the 'Typical Victim'—is that all my search, my existence, is reduced to? I wonder what plagues [anonymous'] mind. Surely, we do not think of the same, for I am truly paranoid. How do I console myself with the social when my soul and solace must be sold?"

* * *

The introduction of Sedgwick's reparative was detrimental to my being. It allowed a framework of thought to become apparent and real, yet very much malleable to my individual and collective needs, still to be discovered. This is especially true as since 2015, Donald Trump has been a voice of influence and POTUS twice. I desperately needed something to aid in the onslaught of abrupt social, cultural, and political changes, as well as my own self-critiquing paranoia.

While I harbor much hatred within my veins, a pain that becomes unbearable sometimes, I believe that my newfound insistence on the reparative is rooted in the non-skeptic grant of humility to interpretations—those held and those to be had—yet also solemn tracing of inspiration, agreement, disagreement, misunderstanding, dis/remembrance, and &c., while maintaining a degree of accountability.

And while this pain brings little joy, it is also a remembrance of my imagination. My existence. My growth. Without these memories of hatred—some that evade me at the most challenging of times, and some that return without request—I would not have developed such a passion in the reparative process. My thoughts, through control I cannot place, became my enemy and my ally. Inspiration pours from every facet of humanity I face. I share my tears and time with my imagination and mortality.

I see my past partner, who left the campus not long after our breakup, in my thoughts, and I see myself, mirrored. Who is to say who was ‘worse?’ In our trajectories, I feel there is reason to believe we were both misguided, and intentions do not seem to mean too much to me anymore. I do not know how they might feel about me: maybe I was the cause of their deeper paranoia, my behavior only codifying what they feared to be true. Maybe I will talk to them, or maybe I will keep looking up at the sky.

What is the cost of thought?

The Expenditure of the Human

Attaching the term 'cost' to the efforts and amalgamation of human thought has always fascinated me. And yet I am the one with an incessant preoccupation with the terminology. To quantify the human consciousness and creation in comparative intent results in an extinguishment of the reparative, outright. But this quantification of self and others is so deeply ingrained in the epistemology of humanity: at our individual core, we come to 'know' the self through opposition and conviction; and even broader, we partake in communal presence by the 'feel' of discernment and presumption of collective intentionality.

Old French regards cost as "outlay, expenditure; hardship, trouble." Old French derives from the Latin *cōnstō*- ("I stand firm (at a price); stand together"). The Proto-Germanic *kust-*, cognate of the Old English *cyst* ("free-will, choice, moral excellence, virtue, goodness, generosity, munificence").²

Ultimately, I feel as though the quantification of human thought belongs to the grandeur of paranoid skepticism. It is a fallacy that mediates the limited choices held by mortal lifeforms (I think of St. Augustine's predilection for equating the trinity of the human soul, the faculties of intellect, memory, and will, as unity to a Godhead)³ while displacing the emotion of knowing to a grandeur form that becomes apparent only after a life has ended.

² https://www.oed.com/dictionary/cost_v?tl=true

³ St. Augustine of Hippo in Olney, James. *Memory & Narrative: The Weave of Life-Writing*. Chicago; London, University of Chicago Press, 1998.

It is through this ‘control’ that apotheoses are created with self-regulating subjects at the forefront of differentiation from one another. It has felt to me, for quite some time, that many theological paradigms create this distinction of self-critiqued identities and the moral judgment by non-material deity: obviously, this is not a new observation, but it is also an interpretation in the context of my observations. And it exists now, on this page. I say this because I admit I am suspicious of the overemphasis on abstraction, both in and beyond the theological realm.

Is the cost of thought human virtue? Of free will? Of togetherness?

* * *

I like to imagine that the mysteries of existence placed before and after us are retained in memories of the past. Maybe it’s true, maybe it’s not.

I do not like to know that some of living humanity regards those mysteries as mystified beyond life. To presume that there is a benevolent, non-material master of mortal fate that transcends human morality often leads to a misrecognition of moral humanity: it is an application of paranoia that derives from the obfuscation of self-pursued will and attempts to appoint mortal beings as representatives of an all-knowing ‘master.’

Over time, I believe that this mystification of ‘master’ as a through-line of knowledge regarding humanity has directed the epistemes of knowing and feeling to a strange realm that seeks certainty amid individual and collective chaos, while concomitantly aware of its inability to acquire substantiated evidence and rational on its ‘existence.’ If one is persistent that they might be able to see the “signals” and respond “appropriately” (i.e., Chaos Theory; ‘virtuous deeds’ into Heaven), then they are leading a life within the paranoid position. This position, regardless of corporal positionality, questions the ‘purpose’ of the human intuition, which is always already categorized into a secondary relation of power (the Godhead, aka ‘master,’ is first).

I believe our purpose, amid all this mystery, is to explore how many rooms there are and how humanity continues to navigate the hallways of existence as time continues to march. It is both an individual and collective quest, for as Milton reminds us, “the mind is its own place,” and perhaps the cost of thought is beyond munificence. Perhaps prescribing self-inflicted shame as a condition for encouraging generosity or goodness is an illogical attempt at corralling humanity under power relations, or perhaps it can serve as a motivator for reparative action in context. I believe--even with things that feel like bullshit—one must capture the vastness of view, without prematurely avoiding and/or closing doors of interpretation and knowing due to suspicion or fear.

I do not think that insisting on metamorphosis against centuries of paranoia and suspicion in our minds is attainable. It is what has kept humanity alive (and more so in the cases of those harmed by self-appointed mortal “masters” of fate)—but we can avoid paralysis in the noise through an imagination that existence can be sustainable otherwise.

Momentum of the Re/Description of Imagination

Often, I must remind myself to watch where I place my steps. But each time I look at my feet, I lose balance. I tumble further into the ground and realize; I am not alone.

7 July 2024:

I want to make something of this (of what ‘this’ is, I am not sure, or I have surpassed my own capability). I am in Nebraska, Tennessee. I am exploring after attempting to find solace in surplus—I need my own space.

I found a small white house; remains are lanterns, chairs, kids' books, and music CDs. I think of life. What was once here, time on a line, staircase cracked and painted with green moss. Finally. Expel my fresh air. The sun will go down soon, and we will do it all again, but I will forget why.

Fireflies glow as I sit with my thoughts—tell me, whisper, how I might continue to live, for I know I cannot die—not yet; I have so much to do, so many smiles to cast on another.

I miss my sister.

* * *

I like to imagine that humanity is good, most of the time. That the hatred in my veins is not my own. I do this through writing my perceived realities in a journal: can any of the entries be considered real?

“You write a thing down because you’re hoping to get a hold on it. You write about experiences partly to understand what they mean, partly not to lose them to time. To oblivion. But there’s always the danger of the opposite happening. Losing the memory of the experience itself to the memory of writing about it” (p.209-210).

Acquiring the reparative is to accept this reality: human thought is as corporeal as the body. We, in our lines of knowledge, of understanding this humanity, have mystified the

awareness of such a fact; the individual and collective memory withstand countless interpretations and re/descriptions through iteration after iteration. However, coincided is the moral acuity that guides the paranoid position, a stance of righteousness that enters with clarity and certainty. We, in our paths of the know/knew/known, have been irreparably sanctioned by the paranoid. We, with limited power, have curated the canonicity of remembrance. Due to this ‘cost’ of thought, humanity has presumably become quantifiable by a non-material ‘measure’—it is exemplified in the “American Dream,” the liberalist pursuits of language, or the American literary authors praised for catharsis while drinking in depression to their demise.

To reckon with the plurality of human existence is to recognize the individual intuition, the awareness that accrues over time regarding the temporality of oneself. A re/description of imagination enables us to visit memory, both spectral and material, through a lens of thought that acknowledges ‘control,’ and therefore, can provide a framework and foundation for reparative work. This reparative includes an almost non-linear relationship with its creator, as the imagination is intimately related to emotional and sentimental realms: these in which can become paradoxical to what is known. Sometimes, the reparative is uncertifiable and false. Perhaps, just a schema inside the mind based on consolidated interpretations—obfuscated once more from ‘reality’—but nonetheless reparative. Sometimes, the reparative is inaccurate and truthful; it could be a singular narrative that concerns multiple interpretations yet provides solace for one individual identity.

Regardless, the momentum of this re/description—the momentum of humanity—is inescapable. This imagination, I believe, operates on a metamorphosing basis: each alteration in intuition continues to gather, sometimes causing an instantaneous change in thought, but each builds upon a malleable foundation that allows us to interpret from the windows in many rooms (every room seems improbable). It provides an opportunity to pursue understanding, knowledge, alongside the temporal emotions that ebb and flow with human existence.

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So, with all that said, maybe I will look at my feet more and lose my balance. I will chase after my feelings, letting all my knowledge drain into the soil beneath me. While my cropped hair blows with the passing minutes and seconds I have in this body, I’ll glance above.

The creases in the clouds have parted ways by now. I know that dusk sky is something of warmth, and it is still filled with whispers of tears. I think I will paint something: not of here or there, but of this wonderfully painful feeling—a shared human sight of serenity.

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